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Unveiling Signification: The Semiotics of Digital Calligraffiti on Western Monuments

Practice-Based PhD Proposal Abstract

In 2021, I proposed projecting Arabic calligraphy onto Ghent's Gravensteen castle using Infi3ctor—a live projection tool I've co-developed since 2016 as part of the global Digital Calligraffiti collective. The city rejected it: **“too politically sensitive.”**

In 2025, my 500m² printed digital calligraffiti **Rooted in Resilience**, featuring poetry by Ghassan Zaqtan, was commissioned by Viernulvier and lit up its facade in the same city. Same visual language. Same artist. Two opposing responses.

This PhD emerges from that tension. It unfolds through practice: creating new digital calligraffiti interventions that test the boundaries of who gets to speak in European public space. These projections aren't illustrations of theory, they are the research.

My work draws on a decade-long engagement with Digital Calligraffiti, a collective practice that amplifies handwritten Arabic script onto urban surfaces in real time. **Infi3ctor** which was designed to be transparent, immediate, and human-centered that turns the gesture of the hand into monumental light. It's been used from Beirut to Berlin, and in Ghent as early as 2020 and beyond.

But this project isn't about the tool. It's about what happens when Arabic script appears on stone that is tied to the Crusades or colonial memory. Whose presence is celebrated? Whose speech is censored? And why does the same act shift from “threat” to “art” depending on who authorizes it?

The artistic output of live projections, documentation, and public encounters forms the core of the inquiry. A written reflection will accompany it, using semiotics and urban theory not to explain the work from afar, but to trace the questions it stirs in real time.

This is a research that happens in the street, in the glare of the projector, in the silence after a word appears where it “shouldn't.”

The answers won't be written first. They'll be projected.

Keywords: Practice-Based Research, Digital Calligraffiti, Public Art, Semiotics, Urban Intervention, Institutional Critique, Ghent, Infi3ctor, Decolonial Memory.